

A weekly review of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- Ofsted's annual refresh of the inspection toolkit and operating guide for 2026/27 is now in effect, covering early years, schools, independent schools, FE & skills and ITE providers.
→ **For your school:** *Skim the schools-specific changes now rather than waiting for your inspection window.*
- KCSIE 2026 came into force on 1 September, bringing a new information-sharing duty under the Children's Wellbeing and Schools Act 2026 and removing the 'supervision exemption' for adults working with children.
→ **For your school:** *Confirm your DSL has reviewed the new information-sharing and AI-safeguarding provisions against your current policy.*
- Two SEND funding/reform consultations — on education otherwise than at school (EOTAS) and a new 'local SEND inclusion formula' for upfront mainstream funding — both close 18 September.
→ **For your school:** *Get any school or trust response in before the deadline; both feed directly into the Schools White Paper reforms.*
- The new 'Experts at Hand' service — speech and language therapists, occupational therapists and educational psychologists working directly alongside mainstream schools — starts rolling out locally this term, backed by around £1.8bn over three years.
→ **For your school:** *Ask your local area what its Experts at Hand offer will look like and when your school can expect access.*

DATES FOR THE DIARY

- 18 Sep 2026** — DfE EOTAS (education otherwise than at school) consultation closes.
- 18 Sep 2026** — DfE 'local SEND inclusion formula' (upfront mainstream funding) consultation closes.
- 18 Sep 2026** — Rotherham Schools Forum meets — agenda includes the exclusion & suspensions annual report and an EHCP update.

■ OFSTED & ACCOUNTABILITY

- **September 2026 inspection toolkit and operating guide now in effect.** Ofsted's annual update to its inspection materials for the 2026/27 cycle covers early years settings, state-funded schools, non-association independent schools, FE & skills providers and initial teacher education. It builds on the report-card framework introduced in November 2025 — a five-point scale (exceptional, strong standard, expected standard, needs attention, urgent improvement), with safeguarding judged separately as met or not met — and sharpens focus on outcomes for pupils with 'barriers to their learning or wellbeing'. ([Ofsted](#))

→ **For your school:** *Check the updated toolkit's treatment of pupils with barriers to learning — it's now an explicit line of inspection enquiry.*

■ SAFEGUARDING & WELLBEING

■ **KCSIE 2026 in force from 1 September.** The updated statutory guidance introduces an information-sharing duty stemming from the Children's Wellbeing and Schools Act 2026, requiring safeguarding organisations and practitioners to share relevant information; schools will also get notifications on domestic abuse incidents and pupils in temporary accommodation in some circumstances. Separately, the Crime and Policing Act 2026 removes the 'supervision exemption', so anyone teaching, training or supervising children is now in regulated activity regardless of supervision. New provisions also cover generative AI use and updated online-risk categories. ([GOV.UK / NSPCC](#))

→ **For your school:** *Check your safer-recruitment checks reflect the regulated-activity change — this affects volunteers and unqualified staff who supervise pupils.*

■ INCLUSION & SEND

■ **Two funding/reform consultations close 18 September.** The EOTAS consultation covers oversight and quality assurance of education arranged outside school for children with EHC plans; the linked 'local SEND inclusion formula' consultation, open since 10 July, tests giving mainstream schools more SEND funding upfront rather than via high-needs top-ups, from the 2027/28 financial year. ([GOV.UK](#))

■ **'Experts at Hand' service begins rolling out.** Local areas are starting to expand access to speech and language therapists, occupational therapists, specialist teachers and educational psychologists working directly alongside mainstream schools, early years settings and colleges — backed by roughly £1.8bn over three years as part of the Schools White Paper reforms. ([GOV.UK](#))

→ **For your school:** *Ask your local area for its rollout timeline and how to request support for a specific pupil or cohort.*

■ FUNDING

■ **Free school meals expansion now in effect.** From this September, FSM eligibility extends to all households receiving Universal Credit, regardless of earnings; schools should expect eligibility-recheck activity through the term as transitional protections from the previous system unwind. ([GOV.UK](#))

■ **Inclusive Mainstream Fund's first year.** The fund is worth over £500m a year, with roughly £400m going directly to mainstream schools for primary and secondary provision — 2026/27 is its first year of operation. ([GOV.UK](#))

■ **Academy funding agreements no longer published centrally.** From this September the department has stopped publishing academy funding agreements on GOV.UK; trusts must now publish redacted versions on their own websites — worth checking your trust's site reflects this. ([Tes](#))

→ **For your school:** *If you're a trust comms lead, confirm your redacted funding agreement is live on your own website.*

■ NATIONAL POLICY

■ **DfE Update, 9 September 2026.** The department's regular fortnightly bulletin to schools, trusts and local authorities was published this week; these updates typically carry grant deadlines, data-collection windows and operational guidance rather than headline policy, so worth a scan for anything time-limited. ([GOV.UK](#))

■ SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

■ **Body-worn cameras for Sheffield's school crossing patrols.** Sheffield City Council is equipping lollipop patrol wardens at several crossings with body-worn cameras, following incidents of abuse from drivers, to protect staff and support safer routes to school. ([The Star](#))

■ **Rotherham Schools Forum meets 18 September.** The agenda includes the exclusion & suspensions annual report, an EHCP update and early 2027/28 budget planning — a useful read-across given Sheffield's own high-needs budget pressures. ([Rotherham MBC](#))

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

£1.8bn

The funding committed over three years for local areas to design and roll out the new 'Experts at

Hand' service — embedding therapists, specialist teachers and educational psychologists directly alongside mainstream schools.

GOV.UK, local areas prepare new Experts at Hand teams (2026)

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Weekly is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.